

Tanks of the Communist Bloc (cont.)

The combat record of Soviet tanks, particularly as used by client states in the Middle East, suggests that they were inferior to Western tanks in one-on-one encounters. However, the truth is that these states rarely used tanks in accordance with the doctrine for which they were designed. Indeed, Soviet tanks were generally quite sophisticated, especially later in the Cold War, featuring gas turbine engines, Kontakt Explosive Reactive Armor, and the Drozd Active Protection System.

Watertight hull



△ **Type 63**

Date 1963 **Country** China
Weight 20.3 tons (18.4 tonnes)
Engine Model 12150-1 diesel, 400 hp
Main armament 85 mm Type 62-85TC rifled gun

Although similar in concept to the PT-76, the Type 63 is a largely indigenous design. It is powered by two water jets that give it a speed of 7.5 mph (6.5 knots). The Type 63 can swim over long distances, a feature that enables it to cross wide rivers and paddy fields, as well as play a role in amphibious operations.

Smoothbore gun with guided missile capability



Kontakt reactive armor

Ceramic composite armor

▷ **T-64B**

Date 1966 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 43 tons (39 tonnes)
Engine 5DTF diesel, 700hp
Main armament 125mm 2A46M2 L/48 smoothbore gun

An advanced but complex design, the T-64 introduced many new features, notably an autoloader for the gun, which could also fire guided missiles. It was intended for independent tank battalions—the spearhead of the Soviet Army—and was never exported. The breakup of the Soviet Union left the T-64 factory in Ukraine, which has developed the tank further.

125mm smoothbore gun

Composite armour protection

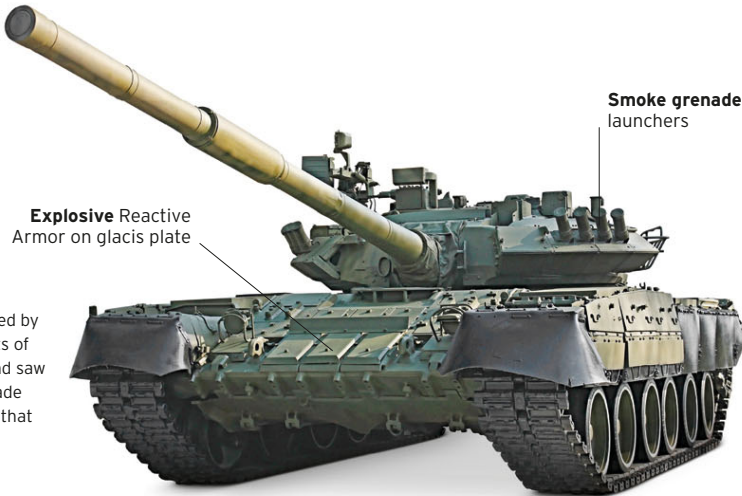


Twelve wheels powered by a V-46 diesel engine

△ **T-72M1**

Date 1973 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 45.7 tons (41.5 tonnes)
Engine V-46.6 diesel, 780 hp
Main armament 125 mm 2A46 M1 L/48 smoothbore gun

Designed as a simpler and cheaper alternative to the T-64, the T-72 has received extensive upgrades over its long career. The latest models are equipped with distinctive Explosive Reactive Armor (ERA) panels and thermal hunter-killer sights. Versions exported by the Soviets generally have less sophisticated systems and thinner armor.



Explosive Reactive Armor on glacis plate

Smoke grenade launchers

▷ **T-80**

Date 1976 **Country** Soviet Union
Weight 50.7 tons (46 tonnes)
Engine GTD-1250 gas-turbine, 1,250 hp
Main armament 125mm 2A46M1 L/48 smoothbore gun

Developed from the T-64, the T-80 was powered by a gas turbine engine. It was seen on the streets of Moscow during the attempted coup of 1991, and saw combat in Chechnya in 1995. This T-80U upgrade has a more powerful turbine and a new turret that is protected by ERA panels.